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Semiotic analysis of the film Parasite

BACHELOR THESIS

Study programme: Applied Informatics

Field of study: Multimedia in the Economic Practice

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Prague, May 2022

Declaration of Authorship

I hereby declare that I am the sole author of this bachelor thesis and that I have not used any sources other than those listed in the bibliography and identified as references. I further declare that I have not submitted this thesis at any other institution in order to obtain a degree.

In Prague, 09.05.2022

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Acknowledgement

I would like to thank my supervisor Mgr. Ing. Tomáš Sigmund, Ph. D. for his valuable advice and patience in the conduct of my bachelor thesis.

Abstrakt

Tato bakalářská práce je zaměřena na sémiotickou analýzu filmu Parazit a má za cíl identifikovat jedinečné znaky filmu, které odrážejí jihokorejskou kulturu a nerovnost ve společnosti a současně analyzovat jejich roli v ději. Účelem práce je analyzovat demonstraci různých tříd ve společnosti a pochopit, zda kulturní znaky filmu mají vliv na vnímání podstaty filmu – kdo je parazit? Práce je rozdělena na dvě části, teoretickou část a praktickou část. Teoretická část se zaměřuje na základní sémiotické teorie a jejich další vývoj v kině, zároveň vysvětlení hlavních aspektů, které tvoří film, jako je struktura a postavy. V praktické části je nástin jihokorejské kinematografie, analýza filmové kultury Bong Joon-ho a samotného filmu Parazit, konkrétněji děj, postavy, a nakonec samotné znaky. Závěrečná část práce vysvětluje originalitu režiséra, důvod jeho úspěchu a možném dopadu na budoucnost kina.

Klíčová slova

film, znak, sémiotická analýza, třída, nerovnost.

Abstract

This bachelor thesis is focused on the semiotic analysis of the film Parasite and aims to identify unique signs of the film that reflect South Korean culture and inequality in society while simultaneously analyzing their role in the plot. The purpose of the work is to analyze the demonstration of different classes in society and to understand if the cultural signs of the film have an impact on the perception of the essence of the film - who is the parasite? The work is divided into two parts, a theoretical part, and a practical part. The theoretical part focuses on the basic semiotic theories and their further development in cinema, as well as explaining the main aspects that make up the film, such as structure and characters. In the practical part, there is an outline of South Korean cinema, the analysis of Bong Joon-ho's film culture, and the film Parasite itself, more specifically the plot, the characters, and finally the signs themselves. The final part of the work answers the question of the director's originality and talks about the reason for his success, as well as the possible impact on the future of cinema.

Keywords

film, sign, semiotic analysis, class, inequality.

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Introduction

Currently, cinema occupies a significant part of cultures of many countries and is one of the most influential media of mass communication. This unique phenomenon is known for its rapid development, global spread, and impact on the audience on a global scale. Synthesizing the achievements of literature, painting, music and theater, cinema has created a new language in which a variety of expressive means are organically intertwined.

Director and screenwriter Bong Joon-ho is considered in the world of South Korean cinema as one of the artists who, with his work, significantly entered the consciousness of film viewers and fans. Since his first student films, he has created very different and memorable works that have something extra compared to other films in the industry. Bong is known for his thought-provoking works, detail-oriented approach to his craft, depiction of flawed characters, and sudden changes of tone from drama to darkness and black humor. These are some of the main signs of the director's style, which has been appreciated by viewers and film critics throughout the world.

One of the important aspects that the work focuses on is film speech, that is, the way the film is presented to the viewer. "Parasite" is essentially about the coexistence of two drastically different families in modern South Korean society. One has everything they need and more and the other is struggling to make ends meet. Bong Joon-ho skillfully showcases the difference between those families as well as similarities with the help of impressive visual architecture, editing and cinematography.

The topic of my thesis falls under the field of semiotics, which examines not only linguistic signs, but also all other sign systems in culture. Therefore, in the first chapter of the thesis, it is necessary to briefly present the initial semiotic concepts, from which we will proceed throughout the subsequent analysis.

1 Semiotics

1.1 Sign

The name “semiotics” itself comes from Ancient Greek σημειωτικός which means “observant of signs”. (Liddell & Scott, 1996)

The main leaders who laid the foundations of it are Ferdinand de Saussure and Charles Sanders Pierce. The former used the term semiology to refer to a “*..science which studies the role of signs as part of social life*” while the latter used the word “semiotic” and described it “*as quasi-necessary, or formal doctrine of signs*”. (Chandler, 1994; Short, 1981)

In this paper, however, semiotics will be used to refer to science about signs, the interpretations behind them, and the way they are conveyed through images, concepts, and so on.

It is also important to note that semiotics is sometimes referred to as semiology although different sources show a variety of approaches to the difference between those terms. Some refer to semiology as only a part of a study which is while some say that it is the same term with the former being an outdated version of it. (Daylight, 2012; Horný et al, 2013).

The main unit of semiotics is sign. In general terms, it can be defined as anything that represents the original object. Everything that surrounds us can be described as a sign system and an informational message. Thus, semiotics turns into a special mode of thinking: a way to see the world exclusively as a sign system and read reality as a book. It is hard at first to fully grasp the reality of signs being everywhere and the fact that they are heavily subjective depending on the situations, places, time, or one’s cultural background. So, for a better understanding let’s explore one of the many examples. If you ask a person from Hawaii to raise a thumb and a pinky, for them it would represent the much commonly used “shaka sign” which conveys the aloha spirit. At the same time, a person from China would think of a number six as that is what is used when one counts on fingers there while in most western countries for decades this hand gesture was and still is for some a sign that represents the action of calling. Although even this interpretation has its own nuance such as that nowadays when you ask a younger individual to show a sign that stands for calling, they would most probably just press their opened palm against their ear which makes sense considering that younger gen z and gen alpha grew up with modern smartphones that do not resemble the thumb and pinky sign at all. Therefore, semiotics becomes an endless adventure that happens to us on the way from “signifiers” to “signified”. This concept will be explained in more detail later in the paper.

1.2 Semiotic analysis

It is safe to state that not everyone understands the meaning behind the same film/scene in the same way. This indicates how complex the interpretation actually is. In semiotics, interpretation stands for the process of identifying a sign and decoding its meaning. Using this approach, we can examine a word used in a title, recurring visuals, or background

music played in the climactic scene as a sign beyond our personal evaluation of the film. The critical task, however, is how to determine the meaning that is embedded in the sign. (Okuyama, 2015)

A very important perception was suggested by Saussure in his book "Course in General Linguistics" which is that concepts have meaning because of their relations to each other, and the basic relationship is oppositional. Therefore "rich" doesn't mean anything unless there is "poor," or "happy" unless there is "sad." There he also tackled different concepts that apply to linguistics as well as proposed the possibility of semiotic analysis.

In general terms, semiotic analysis can be understood as a method of qualitative analysis that deals with the study of signs, codes, and their meanings. And at its core, semiotics as a science of signs, first, considers the structure of language. However, the subject of semiotic analysis can also be art, which was called by another important figure Juri Lotman - a "secondary modeling system", with "primary modeling system" being language. In this sense, we can talk about different types of semiotic analysis. In instances when there is no textual or linguistic accompaniment, the image such as the video sequence in our case, can appear as an independent semiotic code. To summarize, just as every text, image, or message has some meaning, the same meaning can be sought by semiotic analysis in films. (Trampota and Vojtěchovská, 2010, p. 117).

Sign characteristics were mainly dealt with by the Swiss linguist Ferdinand de Saussure, who is considered the founder of structuralism. In the field of semiotics, structuralism can be characterized as an attempt to find a general structure in human behavior and its creations. (Horný et al, 2013, p. 295).

For semiotics, ideas about the structural model of the sign are different. First, there are questions about the degree of structural complexity and the ontological nature of the sign (whether it is an abstract or material entity). And according to F. de Saussure, the model of the sign looks like a two-component structure, where the signified (the object of signification) is defined through the signifier (that by which signification occurs). Saussure defines sign as an inseparable unity of the signifier and the signified meaning there is no signified without a signifier.

Essentially these two play the main role in examining the film as a work of art. What is meant by that is that "signifier" can be referred to any chosen object, while "signified" will then be something that this "object" represents in the particular shot. Another important aspect is that a scene in the movie can also be referred to as "signifier", in this instance, however, "signified" is the meaning behind the picked scene. But what is crucial to understand is that the movie's scene in most cases gives us a clear statement of what the object looks like and what meaning it is supposed to represent, which makes us come to the conclusion that the signifier and signified in the film do not act separately, but, on the contrary, the differences between them are blurred. (Monaco, 2009)

1.2.1 Paradigm and syntagm

According to Saussure, we can distinguish two types of relationships between signs which are paradigmatic and syntagmatic. Both concepts are used in the analysis for effective communication through signs. Consequently, to understand the meaning behind the film we need to first understand what these two terms stand for. (NÖTH, 1998, p. 159)

A paradigm is a set of associated signs that create mutually replaceable choices because they belong to the same specific category, but in which each sign is different from the

others. In our case, it can be comparable to a pool of individual sequences or shots from which the author can choose the ones that he feels would work best together. At the same time, a syntagmatic relationship describes the linear or horizontal relationship between units. It best applies to the linear structure of the film. The plot has to have a meaning and maintain a certain concept for the viewer to understand even in situations when a filmmaker decides on the non-linear structure of the film. (Monaco, 2009, p. 159)

When we analyze a film, we simultaneously perform a paradigmatic analysis, comparing the chosen angle, the actor with other possible ones, etc., as well as a syntagmatic one, comparing the scene with the previous one.

1.2.2 Connotation and denotation

To recognize the codes that the film carries in itself as a medium and to understand the meaning that the film tries to convey to a viewer, it is important to also touch upon the concepts of denotation and connotation. These terms function as levels of signification, which help us to distinguish whether we are talking about some objective fact, or whether the object has some other subjective meaning.

Denotation is understood as a literal, definitional, obvious meaning. It does not capture any subjective description but concentrates only on the obvious definition. At the same time, the term connotation represents other associations that a person might have. These associations can be based on their own experiences, which the individual attributes to the given object. (Trask and Stockwell, 2007)

In film, if connotations become strong enough, they are eventually accepted as denotative meanings, which indicates that the line between denotation and connotation is not defined. It is said that much of the connotative power of film depends on signs that are not arbitrary, but neither are they identical, which inherently stands for indexes. This term will be explained later. (Monaco, 2009, p. 324)

Cinema depicts an object; however, it appears in a special way. A certain object is not just an image, but a thing conditioned by certain connotations given only to it. Hence, thoughts about the subject follow each other, in the order corresponding to these connotations. Objects of physical reality exist in a certain place, they are real and tangible, they exist before they acquire meaning. Cinema can prove the relativity of a given meaning by depicting the same things filled with different meanings at different moments of the film. An image is an unsigned value, a concept, but assumes the qualities of a sign.

Connotative meaning is shown through metonymy which according to Monaco is a *figure of speech in which an associated detail or notion is used to invoke an idea or represent an object*. Relationships are at the core of metonyms. By understanding this term, we can use the White House to signify American administration or Hollywood to express the entirety of American Cinema. In a motion picture, this concept can be conveyed through the depiction of a distorted/blurry shot as a sign of high temperature. (Monaco, 2009, p. 324)

1.2.3 A metaphor in cinema

When a word is used not in its proper, but in a figurative sense, such a figure of speech is called a metaphor. When they say "sheep" about a person or when we hear that a certain person is "a real snake", we understand what trait of the mentioned animals served as the

basis for rapprochement. Cinema, especially cinema of the silent era, willingly resorted to pictorial metaphors. The simplest method of metaphorical transfer is directly borrowed from literature. (Lotman and Tsivian, 1994, p. 169)

Sometimes a role like that of a metaphor is assumed by the image in the image. We often pay attention to the actors and rarely look at the scenery, considering it a conditional and optional background of the action. However, it is useful to remember that the scenery in the film does not arise by chance. The director, the cameraman, and the artist think over all the details of the frame, and if we want to fully understand the idea of the film, we should not neglect the things around the main action.

1.2.4 Icon, index, symbol

In addition to Ferdinand de Saussure, American philosopher - Charles Sanders Pierce is also considered a pioneer in semiotics. He distinguished three types of signs: icon, index, and symbol.

	icon	index	symbol
method of signification	resemblance	causal connection	agreed on conditions
examples	pictures, onomatopoeic words, sound effects imitating real sounds in movies	laughter/happiness, dark clouds/rain, fever/infection	letters in alphabets, words, flags, number systems, computer codes, punctuation marks, traffic signs

Figure 1. Types of signs according to Charles Pierce

Source: Author

- An icon or an iconic sign is a sign that has a known natural resemblance to the object to which it refers. That is, its action is based on the actual similarity of the sign and the object it refers to.
- An index is a sign whose action is based on the real contiguity of the signifier and the signified. The form of these signs is not random unlike symbols, but also is not a direct repetition of the form like iconic signs. The form of index signs is connected with the referent by certain relations - for example, causal.
- A symbol is a sign whose action is based on a conditional connection is established "by agreement" between the signified and the signifier. The connection between the signifier and the signified does not mean a separate object or thing and depends on the mentality of a particular culture. Symbolic signs are often metaphorical in nature and replace the designated object in discourse.

Icon, index, and symbol are among the key divisions of sign, which help the viewer to decode the film. And while in film, the icon and symbol are easily recognizable, meaning we can interpret them in individual shots, the situation is a little bit more difficult when it comes to indexes. In short, they can be understood as ideas that are offered by the film as they provide viewers with concrete representations. (Monaco, 2009, p. 324)

1.3 Structure

Taking into account that the main idea of this paper is to provide an analysis on the film “Parasite” it appears appropriate to specify what is understood by the word “film”. The film means single media or multimedia entertainment content for distribution or exhibition to the general public by any means and media in any digital media format, film, or videotape. (Law Insider, no date)

When it comes to the subject of this work, we’re talking about the feature film. Two things define it: the running time, which usually spreads from 75 to 210 minutes, and the fact that it’s produced for an initial exhibition in a commercial motion picture theatre. Feature film belongs to visual arts, which is characterized by the appearance of characters, story, environment, narration, etc. It also heavily interacts with literature, theater, music, and visual arts in general which makes it one of the most demanding disciplines. (Law Insider, no date)

Cinema creates its own reality. The landscape that we see on the screen is created by the director and the viewer. The camera, the editing, and the viewer's eye actively shape the world in which the film can exist. The viewer is placed between two realities: as a person immersed in practical life, he belongs to the world of practical life, but as a viewer, he is transferred to the cinema world, which he also perceives as some kind of reality. The peculiarity of cinema as an art is that the simultaneous feeling of ultimate reality and ultimate illusion that it evokes in the audience is stronger than anything that any other type of art can currently give. (Lotman and Tsivian, 1994, p. 19)

The film is seen as a coherent system of interconnected characters and codes. But it has a certain structure, the form of which allows the viewer to understand the work and place it in a certain cultural context.

The structure and dramaturgical construction of the film work is one of the main approaches that characterize the work. The plot of the film and its narrative must be considered in the given time, which the author of the work presents it to the viewer. The mediation of what is happening through narration is one of the topics studied in this work.

Dramaturgy and its basic concepts were formulated by Aristotle, who came up with the basic division of the drama that the story must have the beginning, the middle, and the end. Subsequently, this idea was developed, and the three-act structure took the usual form. This structure was popularized by Syd Field in his book “Screenplay: The Foundations of Screenwriting”. There he explained it as:

Act 1 - the Set-Up, Act 2 - the Confrontation, Act 3 - the Resolution

In act 1 we get introduced to the main characters and the relationships between them as well as get the idea of what the story is about. Act 2 is where the main character usually faces obstacles that prevent them from achieving their goal. And act 3 is where the story achieves its final resolution. This particular part shouldn’t be mistaken for the ending as the ending is only the final shot or a sequence at the end of the whole script. All these components create a story, but to smoothly pass from one part to another, the author decides to add plot points at the end of act 1 and 2 which make the structure subsequently look like:

Act 1 - Plot Point 1 - Act 2 - Plot Point 2 - Act 3

Field defines plot points as *any incident, episode, or event that hooks into the action and spins it around in another direction*. (Field, 2005, p.26)

According to the author, this structure is a paradigm of screenplay, meaning it only works as a guide of how a story can look like and where it progresses from one part to another. How this progression goes, each creator decides for himself. It also doesn't exclude the idea of multiple plot points throughout the story aside from plot points 1 and 2, which were especially highlighted by the author since they are the foundation of the dramatic structure that move the story forward. (Field, 2005, p.21 - 26)

This is a simple but effective narrative structure which is popular among a lot of Western works – from Cinderella to Star Wars. People from the East, however, had a slightly different approach which resulted in another type of narrative structure called kishōtenketsu. It originally appeared in China and was used in poetry. Subsequently, the principle got to Korea and then to Japan, where it found wide application. Kishōtenketsu consists of four parts:

Ki: introduction to the basis of a story, characters. The place of action is being set.

Shō: the development of the basis.

Ten: climax, the occurrence of an unforeseen event that significantly complicates the situation.

Ketsu: the conclusion, the results, or consequences of “Ten”.

The difference between the three-act structure and kishōtenketsu is in the former the conflict is the main force behind the whole story, meaning it cannot exist outside of conflict. The latter, however, introduces the conflict or a new element later in the work resulting in the complete change of the story. The plot points of the western structure serve to resolve the conflict. But in Kishōtenketsu, the turn of events serves to surprise and make you look at the situation differently. (Thang, 2021)

As was mentioned earlier, this structure's main purpose is to guide. However, the interpretation depends on a creator and a lot of other factors. Bruce Block in his book “The Visual Story: creating the structure of film, television, and visual media” says that pictures whether they are still or moving which can be said about film are built on three cornerstones: story, visuals and sometimes sound. (Block, 2008, p. 12)

One of the main points of the story are characters and their dialogues. But when talking about film, we can add another very important aspect which is sound. It was the introduction of sound into film production that contributed to the emergence of new genres and increased emotional impact on the viewer. By sound, we perceive not only the conversation between the characters, but also sound effects, different natural noises and, of course, musical accompaniment which is one of the main aspects that help create a certain mood.

According to Block, there are several other parameters that complete the overall concept of the film. Although we might think that their use in the film is obvious, these basic visual components are incredibly important.

The author of the book distinguishes seven basic visual components which are space, line, shape, tone, color, movement, and rhythm. Each of these elements is necessary for the story. Thus, rhythm can not only be heard by the viewer, but it can also be seen as it can be expressed with the help of editing. Overall, some of the components are quite obvious for the normal perception of the moving image, and the recipient has no need to think about them or analyze them but it doesn't make their role less crucial. (Block, 2008, p. 12)

Among the other necessary components that support the overall structure of the story are the technical aspects. The main elements highlighted by Lotman are lighting, editing, playing with plans, changing the speed. Thanks to a successful combination, a combination of these elements, it becomes possible to attach other, additional meanings to the objects. Although it may seem that these are only technical details, they are of a great importance in constructing and decoding the story due to their influence on the perception. For instance, whether the scene conveys more of a hopeful vibe using warm colors and general amount of light or, conversely, the colors make the story more dramatic like, for example, in black and white film. (Lotman, 1998, p. 34)

Lighting creates a significant increase in the sphere of artistic choices. Even the most "natural" lighting in the film, as a rule, is imitated with the help of lighting devices. The antithesis of "normal" ("calm") lighting, supposedly coming from natural sources, and sharp, fluctuating, "abnormal" light with emphatically artificial sources (torches, bonfires, fires, car headlights) creates the possibility of choosing the atmosphere and mood of the frame.

A separate category, which is another key point in building a story, is the characters, or the selected actors. When we read a book, our brain creates a visualization of what we are reading. Since the reader does not see the main character, he has no choice but to imagine him, to visualize him. But the film does not offer this possibility of "imagination". This choice for the viewer was made by the creators. The characters in the film are the ones that tell the story. They move the plot forward and make it so-called real. Much of what the author wants to convey to his viewer is based precisely on the representatives of the characters in the story. This, too, is an argument why some directors choose the same actors for their roles. Like, for example, Song Kang-ho who has played lead roles in multiple films of Bong Joon-ho.

1.4 Film as a language

The film and its structure act as a language system. Yuri Lotman defines art by the concept of "secondary modeling system", since it is a means of communication, and any communication system can be defined as a language. He divides the language into three types: "a) natural languages (for example: Russian, French, etc.); b) artificial languages: languages of science (metalanguages of scientific descriptions), languages of conditional signals (for example, road signs), etc.; c) secondary languages (secondary modeling systems) – communication structures, built over the natural language level (myth, religion).

"Since human consciousness is a linguistic consciousness, all kinds of models built on top of consciousness – including art – can be defined as secondary modeling systems" (Lotman, 1998, p. 20-21)

Although there is an absence of a grammatical system in the film, the film syntax completely replaces it and just as individual sentences and entire stories that are told need some structure and boundaries, so does film.

The film syntax has developed naturally, it is not burdened with clear rules that must be followed but this was not always the case, as described by Monaco. Like the syntax of written and spoken languages, film syntax is an organic development, is a description rather than a guide, and has changed considerably over the years. (Monaco, 2004, p. 168)

In a written or spoken speech, it is possible to find a linear structure, that is, chains of meanings that form phrases, sentences, and, in the end, the whole story. Sentences have a certain sequence and continuity, and it is impossible to say so or write several things at once. In the film, however, this structure is different. We are talking not only about the time sequence, but also about the sequence in space. These two components, which in the film act on each other, are called editing.

The "Kuleshov effect" led to the most significant conclusion in the entire history of cinema: the juxtaposition of two frames does not just summarize their meanings but creates some new third meaning that is not contained in each of them separately. This juxtaposition of frames, linking them into a single semantic and syntactic whole, is called editing.

The theory and practice of editing were closely connected with the research on the issues of poetic language, intensively conducted in the Soviet Union in the first post-revolutionary years. The concept of a word, an integral indivisible unit of meaning, was transferred to the frame. Editing in the narrow sense is the gluing of two frames together. In a broad sense, editing is any juxtaposition of parts of a film that have some sort of artistic significance, for example, the parallelism of two or more sequences of movie frames. Whenever an element of a film — a gesture, a pose, an act, a whole frame, a group of frames — enters a semantic relationship with another of the same element, we are dealing with editing. The distance between the elements can be close and far but overall, it should be just enough to be kept in memory. The second element should vividly evoke the image of the first in our memory and enter complex semantic relations with it. Lotman refers to editing as one of the rhetorical figures of the film language. (Lotman and Tsivian, 1994, p. 23)

According to Lotman, an element can become a carrier of information if it has at least one alternative. An element can be considered as a carrier only if its appearance in the text was not automatic but because of the author's choice. For example, in poetry, a poet can choose a particular word, in painting — paint, pose, arrangement, etc. The same decision, depending on whether it was made in the absence of a choice or as a result of the choice will have a completely different informational meaning. For example, if a director shot a black-and-white film before the invention of color film, it was a forced decision, it had no alternative and, therefore, did not carry any information load. The decision to shoot a black-and-white film nowadays, however, means something. (Lotman and Tsivian, 1994, p.20)

The modern viewer unwittingly attributes their rejection of color to their directors, although in reality there was no opportunity to make color films before. By doing this, the viewer increases the semantic capacity of the film, and the tape becomes more significant to him in comparison to what it was for its creators and the first viewers.

An important element of the grammar of cinema is the causal relationship between two frames: in the first frame a door opens, or a shooting person is shown, in the second someone enters an open door, or we see a falling body.

Since the film can transfer multiple meanings to the canvas at one time, the structure of the film does not necessarily have to adhere to a linear sequence. The film also has the advantage over narrated or written text that, thanks to technology and cameras, it can convey a lot of meanings. Rapid movement of the camera can replace even thousands of words and can express certain storylines much more comprehensively. Thus, the film replaces the complex character system. It is not a language, but it works as a language. Metz would later say that cinema is not a language but a language of art. (Metz, 1991, p. 64)

Christian Metz dealt with the difference between film language and language systems, mainly based on the concepts of langue and parole, with the interpretation of which came up Ferdinand de Saussure. While langue represents language and language system, parole represents speech. Parole is a concrete realization of langue. The film could therefore be described as an act of parole, or a concrete realization of language. (Araki, 2015)

Christian Metz further supported his theory of comparing film to language by claiming that film is, like any other language system, a system of characters and codes that is somehow accepted. (Metz, 1991, p. 75)

For a film to be analyzed we need to understand that film is a visual text. The meaning in film can be retrieved due to its multimodal nature. According to the multimodal approach, all the semiotic modes that exist within the film text which are the spoken mode, the written mode, the mode of music, the mode of sound effects and the mode of moving images are considered altogether to ultimately convey the meaning to the viewer. (Chuang, 2006)

Film is different from its other artistic counterparts. If comparing with novels, film gives room to a more in-depth work with details as well as a relative freedom from prejudice. Theater on the other hand is more like the art of film but even then, it loses to it in terms of the precision of visual potential of the pictorial arts and narrative capability. When talking about photography, film can represent reality on a much higher level because of the interaction of movement, sound, and visual images. (Monaco, 2009, p.58)

Comparing film to music is complex because as much as they are similar to each other, they are also essentially different but what makes it quintessentially different and therefore attractive is that film can be used to record most of the other arts as well as interpret almost all the codes and tropes common to narrative, pictures, music, and dramatic arts. (Monaco, 2009, p.88)

1.4.1 Color vs Black-and-white

One of the eye-catching aspects of the arts is color. Through it the artist can convey a lot of emotional information to a viewer. It is apparent that black-and-white palette communicates significantly less visual information than the one full of color. That can negatively affect the viewer's involvement in the overall story. But at the same time for the artists who are not afraid of the challenge, black-and-white palette can help in improvement in composition, tone, and mise-en-scène.

1.5 Semiotics of culture

The "language barrier" erected by the speaking cinema can act in two ways. On the one hand, it impoverishes the film and complicates its perception of a foreign culture. But art is not a telegraph, it itself often prefers the path of difficult understanding to the easy way. It is not consumption, but a process. Therefore, on the other hand, language and cultural barriers often enrich the perception of the film. Art helps us to see familiar things in an unusual light. Ignorance of the language, way of life, and stereotypes of thinking of another culture often contribute to this work of art, turning watching a movie into discovering a new world. (Lotman and Tsivian, 1994, p. 144).

In Charles Peirce's semiotics, the central concept is a sign, which he considers any object replacing another object that is not divided into smaller components relevant from a semiotic point of view. In accordance with his concept, simple single signs can form more complex systems of signs, which together form a language. According to Pierce, semiotics of culture is a section of semiotics that explores sign formations found in various cultures. But neither culture occupies any special position in relation to semiotics, nor semiotics in relation to culture. (Pierce, 2000, p. 63)

At the same time, Russian- Estonian semiotician Lotman considers culture as a hierarchy of particular semiotic systems, as a sum of texts and a set of functions correlated with them, or as some device generating these texts. (Lotman, 2002, p. 516)

Representatives of the Tartu-Moscow Scientific School, who took an active part in the development of the semiotic approach, created holistic semiotics of culture. In their understanding, semiotics and culture are interrelated. The basis of culture consists of semiotic mechanisms associated, firstly, with the storage of signs and texts that determine the memory of culture, its connection with tradition, and support the processes of its self-identification. Secondly, with their circulation and transformation, which determine intracultural and intercultural communication. And thirdly, with the generation of new signs and new information that provide the opportunity for innovation and are associated with a variety of creative activities.

According to Lotman, culture is primarily a semiotic system, a structure of elements and rules for combining them in a fixed analogy to the whole sphere of the object of knowledge, insight, and regulation. From this definition, the most important part is that the system is a construction and a methodological, cognitive tool applied in the analysis. (SEMENENKO, 2012, p. 23)

It is a complex system that consists of several languages or codes at the same time. The text belongs to two or more languages at the same time. They argue that human perception is heterogeneous, divided into two, where one perceives the world as a discrete coding system, the basic unit of which is the sign, and the other perceives it as a continuous system, where the basic unit is the text. It serves as a means of communication between people. (LOTMAN and ECO, 1990. P. 36)

According to a broader definition, communication between two or more individuals can be called a language. In the language of culture, however, the message is not received, but is translated to the recipient-that is, the recipient of the message can interpret the message in different ways. An important feature of culture is that it can generate new messages. The communication of road signs is given as an example – in it, if we know the language of road signs, that is, we know all road signs, we also know all the messages that this language can convey. (SEMENENKO, 2012, p. 27-28)

1.6 Semiosphere

Juri Lotman put forward the idea of the semiosphere as a result and condition for the development of culture. In his opinion, no unambiguous systems can exist by themselves as they are extracted from a certain living environment, "*a semiotic continuum filled with semiotic formations of different types and located at different levels of organization*". He calls such a continuum a semiosphere. In essence, it is equal to culture, because it is a necessary prerequisite for communication. (Lotman, 1992, p. 12-13)

Lotman contrasts two approaches. The first is non-systemic: the consideration of the semiotic universe as a set of closed individual texts and languages which he compares to separate bricks of a building. And the second approach is a systemic one, which consists of the fact that the entire semiotic space appears as a single living semiotic organism, the primary link of which is not a separate brick (elementary sign), but a whole system called the semiosphere. It is a space and a condition of meaning, without which it is impossible to interpret the text of culture. A vivid image illustrating this idea is the gluing of steaks, which does not lead to a live calf. (Lotman, 1992. p. 14)

The semiosphere is the construct of the semiotic method, in other words, it can also be said that the semiosphere is examined by semiospheric means. Then we distinguish the semiosphere as a whole as a prerequisite for semiosis and the semiosphere, a specific semiotic space that is described or analyzed. The aim of the analysis is to reconstruct the real semiosphere of the text. One can then observe the relationship between the meaning-generating space and a certain message, thereby trying to determine the ideal audience for the text. The credibility of the interpretation then depends on how perfectly it is possible to reconstruct the semantic life of the analyzed text. (SEMENENKO, 2012, p. 120)

The semiosphere is a condition for the existence and operation of individual languages, which precedes them and constantly interacts with them. "*There is no communication or language outside the semiosphere*" (Lotman, 2000. p. 250).

Language in the semiosphere is a "*function, a clot of semiotic space*", just as the living substance of the biosphere is its naturally expressed function. In the semiotic space, the boundaries between languages appear blurred and full of transitional forms. The mandatory laws of the construction of the semiosphere are binary and asymmetry. Binary is realized as multiplicity: a new language appears because of binary fragmentation of an existing language, which eventually leads to a plurality of languages. So, for example, the art of cinema after its formation immediately divided into artistic and documentary, photographic and animated. The emergence of new languages is accompanied by the disappearance of the former ones, as a result of which the diversity of semiotic means within culture is a relatively constant value. The asymmetry is manifested in the ratio "*the center of the semiosphere – its periphery*", where the center is formed by the most developed and structurally organized languages, primarily the natural language of a certain culture (Lotman, 2000, p. 254.).

Culture and the semiosphere undoubtedly have the same functioning. However, the semiosphere, in the general sense as a prerequisite for semiosis, is an obvious primary condition for the existence of any culture. In other words, culture is a product of the semiotic activity of man, and the semiosphere is a model for the unique semiotic ability of people. (SEMENENKO, 2012, p. 124)

2 Class disparity in film

Cinema, one way or another, has always been used to reflect real life, actual social phenomena, so the representation of social problems in Western film products is not surprising.

According to a study conducted by psychologist T. Salahieva-Talal, cinema is a mirror of our life and social phenomena. The author has identified several stages of the development of society, reflected in the cinema. Each period of the development of society has its own type of plot and its main character.

Three main periods are characteristic of the film products of Western society. The first is the period of the Second World War. The main value inherent in this time stage is attachment to the group, unity, and protection from danger. The films of that time represented a selfless brave man who sacrifices himself for the common good. As an example, the author of the study cites the film by American director Michael Curtis "Casablanca" (1942), whose hero sacrifices a successful business and the love of his life for the sake of helping refugees to the New World.

The next period is the development of narcissistic society from 1950 to 1970. The characters in the films are self-oriented and strive for individual realization. A new model of cognition appears – "I am myself", and relationships are sacrificed to personal freedom. There is a need for individuation at the social level, which manifests itself in the struggle for the rights of minorities, both racial and gender. The main themes of this period in American cinema were Native Americans ("The Broken Arrow", 1950), African Americans ("On the Outskirts of Town", 1957) and immigrants ("12 Angry Men", 1957). This stage coincided with the release of the first film about James Bond. He is the embodiment of the narcissistic ideal of society: immaculate, strong, and independent.

In the UK, the representative of the narcissistic rebellion was a group of critical writers and filmmakers – "Angry Young People". The film "Look Back in Anger" (1959) directed by Tony Richardson marked a new stage in British cinema, which denounced the state, the church, and the upper class. In France, this wave rebelled against the old methods of cinema, and created a new hero who stood against social norms for the sake of his own self-realization. In other words, the main conflict of post-war society is the confrontation between the individual needs of a person and the system, not only at the level of an individual, but also at the family, social and political levels.

Such a process of self-realization through rebellion and narcissism has led society to a state of confusion, which will later lead to a new era of border society. The revolt against the system led to violence, destruction and disintegration of the traditions and values of the parent society. The film "Bonnie and Clyde" (1967) became a defining act of rebellion through violence and led American society to a new counterculture and the emergence of a New Hollywood.

The period from 1970 to 1990 was characterized as the era of technological frontier society. This is the time of machines and technology. Emotions and feelings cease to be important in society, the only thing that matters is labor productivity. On the one hand, people in such a society have the illusion of their exclusivity, on the other – they feel like impostors. Such a state gives rise to confusion and uncertain boundaries, ambivalence, and inability to separate from society to find oneself. Cinema in this period is

characterized by purposeless, destructive, and self-destructive characters. Following the film "Bonnie and Clyde", the films "Taxi Driver", "Flying over the Cuckoo's Nest", "Clockwork Orange" are released, the heroes of which, overcome everything with rage, destroying both themselves and the world around them.

Another characteristic feature of the frontier society era was the appearance of blockbusters. During this period, people needed clear and precise guidelines, so the cinema began to use the model of the black-and-white world. A rather rigid categorization and division of the world into good and evil followed. A striking example of a blockbuster of that period is the Star Wars trilogy by George Lucas. (Salahieva-Talal, 2021)

Social problems are an integral part of society so they can't help but get reflected in the cinema. Films on the topic of class inequality have always sought recognition from the public due to their relevance to the bigger part of the population. Thus, one of the earlier depictions of class divide can be seen in a German movie "Metropolis" (1927). The action of the film takes place in the future where the huge city is separated into two parts. The ones that rule the city live in the skyscraper while simple workers are stuck underground in the industrial hell.

One of the sub genres that depict different classes in film is a "stairway movie" genre which was mentioned by Bong Joon-ho in his interview to Vulture. Generally it portrays class divide through staircase which represents the vertical class system. Thus, the motif of verticality is present in Parasite from the beginning till the end. Usually, the term "stairway movie" applies to the horror films as they are often used to represent the current fears of society. The main characters in those kinds of films are usually underdogs that strive for a better life but when reaching the climax, they discover that there is in fact a level below them and they are confronted with the existence of people who are in much harsher conditions. Aside from Parasite, some of the examples of stairway movies are "People Under the Stairs" (1991) and "Us" (2019). Just like in "Parasite" the basement, and stairs, or rather the escalator in the case of the film "Us" are used as a metaphor of a declining mental state of the less fortunate. (Jung, 2020)

Vertical class separation is also inherent in the "Titanic" (1997). This film is loosely based on real events, therefore, as well as in real life, people are divided into classes from the first to the third. The first class, which represents rich people, lives in a luxurious but essentially toxic environment while people from the third class, although poor, but in the end have a warmer relationship between each other. The rich and the poor can be easily spotted by their behavior as well appearance. In the film, they are trying to show us that there is a huge difference between people of the first and third class and that Jack would never fit into this category, even though he was given a beautiful suit. The difference is especially noticeable when the liner begins to sink and the best seats on the boats go to the first class.

The success of "Parasite" can be compared to the success of "Slumdog Millionaire" in 2008. That film was able to win the Oscar in 8 categories and bring the authors financial success. The story, shot in India, talks about the same eternal class inequality through a love storyline and a uniquely Indian entourage. As such, one can cite stereotypical examples, such as scenes in the tech support center. In India, the strong contrast of classes is especially noticeable and there are still echoes of the caste system. The directors of this film used these elements to embellish the story and emphasize the main moral message.

Both films have a developed aftertaste and explore the same topic, but with completely different angles and unique elements of the cultural context. Both films combine genres and appeal to a more universal sense of justice, thereby maximizing their potential audience.

All the previously mentioned films are connected by the topic of social inequality, more specifically class inequality. Taking a closer look, we can notice that they all have common aspects in the portrayal of rich and poor: their differences, as well as similarities. From this we can conclude that the main aspects of the depiction of classes from the early days of cinema were not much different from how it is portrayed today. But specific signs indicating class differences may appear due to the culture of the country where the film is from, as well as the time period.

3 Bong Joon-ho's film culture

It is safe to say that Bong Joon-ho is the most famous South Korean director as of now. Partly because the South Korean or Asian film industry, in general, is still something that the western world struggles to accept without labeling it as “exotic” or “oriental” and partly due to his exceptional talent that made him break the wall and make his mark on popular culture. The fact that someone watches films from an Asian filmmaker is obviously not an unusual phenomenon in the east, but the same thing cannot be said about the west. And if for Western film connoisseurs who are not afraid to watch foreign films from all over the world, names like Kim Kiduk or Park Chan Wook are not just unusual sounding names, but the names of directors who have inarguably contributed to modern world cinema. Then for an ordinary person who only watches what is widely publicized, Bong Joon-ho might be one of the first if not the first directors from the eastern peninsula whose name they were able to remember. This critical and public acclaim is an evident reflection of the director's background.

3.1 History of South Korean cinema

Creative figures can get inspiration from different sources. But what can be said with certainty is that the unique history of the country they come from has a huge impact on what themes prevail in their work, so it only makes sense to consider how the history of Korea influenced the history of cinema and consequently Bong Joon-ho's approach to the art of filmmaking.

Cinema came to the Korean peninsula, which was still united at that time, thirty years later than to other countries as the first motion picture was screened only in the year 1903. The development of cinema coincided with the Japanese colonization — in 1910. Korea became a Japanese colony, and the Japanese used the Korean film market to produce their films. Therefore, Korean directors did not receive funding, and those Korean films that managed to shoot did not make a profit — all box office receipts went to Japan. Korean filmmakers had two options: save up for shooting on their own or agree with the policy of Japanese studios. In addition, there was strict censorship in the country — Koreans could only shoot in certain genres: melodrama, costume drama, and ideologically correct films from the Japanese point of view. It was only in 1924 that the first what is considered purely Korean film “The Story of Jang-Hwa and Hong-Ryeon” was released. (An et al, 2000, p.17)

But the real breakthrough came with the revolutionary film called “Arirang” (1926), which critiqued the Japanese occupation of Korea. After that, Korean films began to appear more often, expressing dissatisfaction with the then-current regime.

Following that, Japan tightened its grip on censorship, and there were fewer Korean films: six films in 1931, four the following year, and only two in 1934. However, the year 1935 became prominent due to the emergence of sound and that is how the film “The Story of Chun-hyang” was released. Koreans heard their native speech on the screens for the very first time, and this became the hope for the revival of national culture. Unfortunately, the

Japanese later increased censorship to the point that only those who spoke Japanese and had a Japanese surname were allowed to appear in films.

More foreign films began to be brought to Korea, the national cinema did not have enough resources to compete at the box office. During the Second World War, only one film was shot in Korea — "Hurrah for Freedom!", it was released in 1946 and became the first film made in the country after it achieved the much-anticipated independence from Imperial Japan.

In 1950, the civil war began, which later divided Korea into North and South. In the new reality, President Rhee Syngman abolished taxes for the film industry, and humanitarian programs from other countries provided South Korea with their technology and equipment. The "golden age" of Korean cinema began. In ten years, the number of films per year has grown 23 times, among them were the films "The Hand of Destiny" (1954), "Boxes of Death" (1955, the first Korean film with synchronous sound), "Yongsan Province" (1955). In 1960, the thriller "The Housemaid" was released, shocking the viewers with the plot's frankness. This film, later on, became one of the inspirations behind Parasite. (Ulaby, 2019)

In 1972, because of a military coup, dictator Park Chung-hee came to power. He restricted foreign films at the Korean box office and ordered Korean film producers to shoot films on a planned basis - at least 15 commercial films a year. Formally, this did not hinder the development of cinema - on the contrary, directors experimented with genres. Since 1979, the country has produced more than 200 films annually with such high sales that the record was broken only in 2005.

However, during the regime of Park Chung-hee and the Fourth Republic, the "golden age" ended. Political censorship appeared again - the authors were obliged to shoot only those films that positively depicted the current government. Cinemas became less popular, and the author's cinema developed underground. Some of the films that were released at that time are "Woman of Fire" (1971) by Kim Ki-young and "Flame" (1975) by Yu Hyun-mok.

The beginning of the 1980s was marked by the establishment of a new government — the Fifth Republic of South Korea. The films "Good Windy Days" (1980) by Lee Jang-Ho and "Madame Aema" (1982) by Jeong In-yeob were released. Both films were revolutionary because the former criticized income inequality, and the latter was the first erotic film made in the country after the government began relaxing its control over the film industry.

Another important period happened with the emergence of the resistance movement in 1987 also called The June Democratic Struggle which was one of the main forces in establishing the present-day Korean government. The change from 26 years long military dictatorship to democratization gave birth to what's called in the history of Korean cinema - the Korean New Wave. Some of the significant names that are associated with this generation of filmmakers are Park Kwang-su, Jang Sun-woo, Chung Ji-young, and Lee Myung-se. These artists were heavily inspired by the newly achieved creative freedom so lots of their works were about the topics that were considered taboo in the country due to the previous regime such as labor movement, division of Korea, and class. (Cho, no date)

As domestic production opportunities have increased, so has competition. Korean directors kept the viewer near the screens by not dwelling on then prevailed politically correct melodramas, but by constantly expanding the boundaries and combining multiple genres, deceiving the expectations of the audience. This turn of events aligned with the emergence of the new generation of filmmakers like Bong Joon-ho, Kang Je-kyu, Park Chan-wook, Kim Jee-woon, Hong Sang-soo, Lee Chang-dong, and Kim Ki-duk.

These directors can all be grouped together based on shared cultural and historical experiences as they all belong to two particular social generations. But expanding on Bong Joon-ho specifically who was born in late 1969, he technically belongs to a 386 generation (named after Intel 386) but it's also important to note that despite that he can as well be grouped with The Democratic Generation which was born between 1970–1980. One of the common characteristics of both generations is their interest in social issues, more specifically the treatment of the unprivileged in the economic system. What made them different from the previous generations is that the main enemy of the student activists was not only the regime or dictatorship but also rising social inequality and unfairness towards people from the lower class. (Yi, 2020)

Creative people have always been among the first to express dissatisfaction with the regime or the government through their art. This concept is nothing new, but it is this generation of directors that could finally talk about then taboo topics such as South Korea's relationship with North Korea, the brutality of government towards activists, and more without worrying so much about censorship, dictatorship, occupation, and what more. (Choe, 2020).

Following South Korean history as combining it with the theories of semiosphere, one might conclude that Parasite's success is the ultimate explosion of South Korean entertainment culture as well as the support of South Korean government that lies in a desire to strengthen the image of the country.

3.2 Background information

Bong Joon-ho was born in the third largest city in South Korea called Daegu. He describes his family as middle class; his father was a graphic designer so it must have had its impact as to why he was not hesitant to pursue a career in a creative field in the first place. Now famous director developed an obsession with old Hollywood movies and bought himself his first-ever camera as early as middle school. And although he knew he wanted to become a director since then, he did pursue a degree in sociology at one of the top institutions - Yonsei University at first. Historically South Korean students were the main force behind lots of political upheavals in the country, so it is not surprising that everyday demonstrations were almost a part of a routine of any student at that time. Bong describes that period of his life as "protest during the day, drink at night". (Jung, 2019)

However the director does say that he would often sneak out of from those protests to watch films back in his room. But what is apparent, as mentioned by his earlier producer Tcha Sung-jai, his worldview was shaped during that time as students couldn't help but become sensitive towards social issues. (Choe, 2020)

While at university, he co-founded a filmmaking club called "Yellow Door" where Bong and other students would watch and analyze various films. So, it was no surprise that in the early 90s the then future director decided to attend one of the top South Korean film schools - Korean Academy of Film Arts (KAFA). That's where he would make his first short films such as "White Man", "Incoherence" and "Memories in My Frame". (Entrevues, no date)

In the industry Bong Joon-ho is known for his preparedness on the filming site. That can be linked to his meticulous storyboards that allow the actors to focus on the emotions that they have to express during one single shot instead of trying to replicate it for cameras from different angles. Bong has been moving with this approach from his very early days and "Parasite" is no exception.

3.3 Bong Joon-ho's filmography

Unexpected tone shifts, emphasis on social issues, black humor, and eye-catching genre-mixing are some of the things a viewer can expect diving into Bong Joon-ho's work. Although the director himself doesn't really want people to watch his early work from back at KAFA, describing it as "terrible", it is still fascinating to see how even in his first films ever such as "White Man" (1994) and "Incoherence" (1994), you can clearly spot Bong's interest in social commentary.

Bong Joon-ho's debut feature film "Barking Dogs Never Bite" (2000) unravels a story about people who live in the same apartment building with the main character being a man who decides to express his frustration over his financial situation in a very disturbing manner, by killing dogs. This film depicts the tragic reality of life and its lack of justice. "Barking Dogs Never Bite", although, not Bong's favorite, still manages to show his passion for social commentary and the blending of various genres. Overall, this movie wasn't successful compared to his following works as it only sold 100 000 tickets.

True appreciation from the public came to the director with the release of his next feature film "Memories of Murder" (2003). Partly based on the actual serial killings in South Korea between the years 1986 and 1991, this film skillfully showcases the country's mood at that time: rallies, the breakdown of society, poverty, brutality, and incompetence of local law enforcement agencies. It received the highest rating for the production, musical accompaniment, direction, and script and made Bong one of the most promising directors in the country.

Following the success, the director's next big project "The Host" (2006) was really anticipated by the audience. It is evidenced by the fact that the film was shown on a record number of screens in its home country. This time Bong decided to share a story that provides a political commentary on the presence of American armed forces in South Korea via monster film. Just as with his previous work, it was also inspired by real-life events and once again displayed the director's talent in genre-mixing.

The next full-length film from Bong Joon-ho, which appeared before the audience, was "Mother" (2009). It shows the heartbreaking realities of the world and its unfair treatment of non-privileged people. An analysis of human nature tells a story of a mother who does everything in her power to prove the innocence of her intellectually disabled son, who was accused of murder. Coming back from high budget production, Bong's work once again received critical acclaim from multiple international festivals as well as the local public, securing Bong Joon-ho's place as one of the most favorable directors in the country.

The major shift came with "Snowpiercer" (2013) which marks the director's first English-language film starring, some known to a western audience actors such as Chris Evans and Tilda Swinton. The director unravels the hyperbolized and at the same time intimidatingly realistic post-apocalyptic story of financial stratification and rebellion as an element of the system through a depiction of the new world where life only glows in a never-stopping train which represents a new society where people are strictly divided into castes. This Czech-South Korean co-production was based on the graphic novel "Le Transperceneige" (1982) and was acknowledged as one of the best-released films of that year.

Following "Snowpiercer", Bong Joon-ho released a multi-lingual film "Okja" (2017) that tells a story of a child's love for a fantastic creature that is hunted by greedy capitalists. It turned out to be a kind of anti-capitalist and anti-globalist statement, which discusses human arrogance, corporate greed, and animal rights activism. This controversial

collaboration with Netflix marked Bong's first time attempt at competing for Palme d'Or at Cannes.

3.4 Common aspects in his previous works

Like lots of other directors, the South Korean director also has his own favorite tricks that get repeated throughout his filmography for viewers to better understand his point across. Some of the most noticeable ones that don't require hyper attention from spectators are:

3.4.1 Genre-mixing

The key charm of Korean cinema in general and Bong Joon-ho is the ability to switch between genres. In most of his films, the director maneuvers quite rapidly between thriller, drama, black comedy, satire, and other genre constructions. Already in the debut feature film "Barking Dogs don't Bite" (2000), the director demonstrated how quickly he could move from Hitchcockian suspense to slapstick, and in "Memories of Murder" (2003) he only consolidated the success. However, "Snowpiercer" (2013) and "Okja" (2017) — are inferior to Korean ones in the dynamics of the change of tonality. The dystopia about the future in the entourage of eternal winter distributes genres into wagons: tragedy, satire, brutal thriller, social drama — and further, as far as imagination and possibilities are enough. In the pamphlet about the genetically modified pig, the director continued to make smoother transitions, fearing to confuse the viewer. In the "Parasite", he returned back to his roots — even if not to the maximum level.

3.4.2 Song Kang-ho

The superstar of South Korean cinema, actor Song Kang Ho is relatively well known in the west thanks to his collaborations with the leaders of the new Korean cinema — Park Chan-wook, Kim Jee-woon and Bong Joon-ho. Song Kang-ho's good-natured, slightly puffy face fits perfectly into the image of an ordinary Korean man. The actor starred in four of Bong's films and played a typical Korean in each of them: a not very smart rural detective in "Memories of Murder", an even more stupid, but heartfelt simpleton in "The Host", then he was responsible for the whole population in "Snowpiercer" and now he has starred in the role of the head of a poor family in "Parasite".

3.4.3 The West

It is interesting that the most known South Korean director often emphasizes the corrupting influence of the West. For example, in "Okja", an American corporation arranges farms to produce the ideal food all over the world. In "The Host", the whole story begins with 200 bottles of formaldehyde being drained into the sewers and the Han River at an American military base. Bong Joon-ho does not blame all the troubles inside the country on the United States, but pointedly denounces both the predatory movements of its foreign policy and the fascination of fellow citizens with the West in general.

3.4.4 Family

Most of the Bong Joon-ho's works revolve around society in one way or another. The criminal intent of the teacher from "The Barking Dog Never Bite" is arranged by a relationship with his pregnant. In "The Host", a mismatched and not too successful family overcomes fire, water and the monster to prove that they are worth something, despite their low social status. In "Mother", the maternal instinct of love for the child is called into question. In "Snowpiercer", the love of a parent for a child becomes one of the auxiliary forces of the local revolution. In "Parasite" — the family alternately pulls all members to the good life, then to the bottom.

3.4.5 Crime

The main aspect of the plot of Bong Joon-ho's movies is often a crime: a dog killing teacher attracts the attention of a girl who works as an accountant ("Barking Dogs Never Bite"). The police investigate serial murders of girls that occur on rainy nights ("Memories of Murder"). A mother is trying to get her simple-minded son out of prison, who is accused of murdering a schoolgirl ("Mother"). And similarly, the plot of "Parasite" is also based on several crimes — however, the most powerful of them come only in the finale.

In the director's early films, it was also possible to meet a characteristic frame: blood flowing from a broken head — for example, it is in both "Mother" and "Parasite". Red in those films appears as accent. And although these accents form a certain logical chain, they are mostly used to designate a shift.

3.4.6 Television

TV is an important hero of most of the films of Bong Joon-ho; even in the post-apocalyptic "Snowpiercer", where, it would seem, there is little time for this. In "Barking Dogs Never Bite" the heroine dreams of getting into a news story to become famous. In "Memories of a Murder," village policemen watch a stupid series about detective work. In "The Host", reports from an infected and attacked area by a mysterious monster inflate the atmosphere according to the precepts of Hitchcock. And in "Snowpiercer", new generations are getting openly zombified by it. The director uses TV both to inform the viewer and to add color to the characters.

3.4.7 Memory

It is not the most obvious motive in the filmography of Bong Joon-ho, but nevertheless very appealing to South Korean history, in which there are enough scars of wars, uprisings and other cataclysms, so the director just cannot bypass it. Memories put pressure on the pedal of guilt in the behavior of Curtis, the leader of the uprising from "Snowpiercer"; they also force people to abandon life on a gigantic train. Memory gnaws at the character of Song Kang Ho in a thriller about a serial killer. The memory of the crime prevents the mother from returning to the wise elderly harmony. And the memory of lost relatives generates a sentimental quasi-happy ending of "Parasite".

3.4.8 Humans as machines

In some of the last films of the director, the viewer at a certain moment discovers the terrible secret of the location of the main characters. Behind the seemingly clear automation there is a person who is on the way to lose his last pieces of humanity. Like than in “Snowpiercer” the main character discovers that behind the never stopping train, there is a small child that operates the whole system while in “Parasite” the inhabitant of the basement pretends to be a movement activated lightbulb.

4 Parasite

Back in his twenties, the creator of Parasite decided to make some extra money by tutoring a child from an upper-class family. What felt like spying on the world of the rich later happened to become an inspiration for an internationally acclaimed thriller.

Bong Joon-ho started working on Parasite back in 2013 while he was finishing the post-production for Snowpiercer. The financial situation in South Korea and all over the world was about the same then as it is now - social polarization, or to keep it simple, there is a huge gap between the poor and the rich. According to a study done by the UN, income inequality has been increasing in most developed countries for over decades. The rich keep getting richer, while the poor have almost no chance of escaping poverty. This disturbing fact confirms the size of the overall problem. Therefore, with Parasite being a visual demonstration of this harsh reality, it is no wonder that people all over the world could relate to the story. (United Nations, 2020)

Even though the topic of class difference isn't something new in the director's filmography, this time he specifically decided to focus on his home country. (Moskvitin, 2020)

Parasite started out as a play. The restrictions of theater made Bong create the story in which the main action would go down in a limited place, which is why much of the film is located in just two houses. (Sims, 2020)

This can also be explained by the fact that one of the inspirations for Bong was a crime drama that has become a classic "The Housemaid" (1960), which also like "Parasite" almost entirely takes place within the walls of one house and reveals the theme of social mobility, money and inequality. Similar themes are also brought up in the 2007 film called "Secret Sunshine". In addition to the fact that both Parasite and Secret Sunshine got nominated for Palme d'Or at Cannes Film Festival in their respective years, they also showcase the struggles of a lower class. Although the 2007 film does so through the exploration of religion. (npr, 2019)

Multiple accolades inside and outside of South Korea made Parasite an instant classic.

4.1 Plot

Like the previous films of Bong Joon-ho, Parasite is no exception to the rule and serves as a collection of several genres. The work can be perceived as two films in one. The first part tells the story of an ordinary poor unemployed South Korean family of four, the Kims. With the help of a friend and a forged education document, the son of a family (Ki-woo) gets a job as a tutor for Da-hye, a daughter from a high-class family (the Parks). Having successfully infiltrated there, he manages to deceive a rich family and subsequently gets a job for his sister (Ki-jung) as an art therapist for Da-song, the Park family's son. Later they also manage to steal the jobs for their father (Ki-taek) as a chauffeur and their mother (Chung-sook) as a housekeeper, while simultaneously hiding the fact that they are relatives. One day, while taking advantage of the departure of the Parks on a trip outside the city, the four decide to celebrate the fruits of their snarky plan in a house empty of bosses. Amid their celebration, the previous employee (Gook Moon-gwang) who got her job stolen by the Kims, rings the doorbell. This scene is the transition to the next part of

the film when we finally get to the thriller. It turns out that there is a bomb shelter in the house, in which the husband (Oh Geun-sae) of a former employee lived for over four years. Unfortunately for the family of four, the couple finds out about the secret of Kims' relationship, which leads to a brawl, which is won by the family of four. At the same time, a downpour begins, which prevented the trip of a rich family thus they notify about their arrival home. The Kims dramatically clean up the house, kick the previous employee and her husband into the shelter, and almost get caught in the act but eventually they manage to return to their home, where all their property was destroyed by the flood. Unaware of the poor family's tragedy, the mother of a wealthy family (Choi Yeon-gyo) invites the Kims to a celebration. There, hoping to hide the secret of his family, Ki-woo decides to kill the couple in the bunker, but his plan tragically fails. In the end, everything results in his head injury and the death of his sister at the hands of Geun-sae. This in turn provokes Ki-taek to attack the father of a rich family (Park Dong-ik). The film ends with Ki-woo hoping to free his father, who fled to the bunker in order to avoid punishment for the attack.

4.2 Characters

Kim Ki-woo

The first character that appears in front of the audience is Ki-woo - the only son of the Kim family, a smart young man who just wants a better life. From the very beginning, we notice that he is a quick thinker, as he finds a video which helps the family to stack pizza boxes in a much faster way and he was the one who managed to make an opportunity for his sister to obtain a job as an art therapist. In the first minutes of the film, Ki-woo tries to arrange an interview for himself while simultaneously bringing down the current worker which he shows no guilt for doing. This is also a foreshadowing for how in the future Ki-woo and his family will do the exact same thing, but on a larger scale. With all the determination that he showed while trying to get a job in a pizzeria, we later notice that he is not a very confident person. While talking to his friend Min, Ki-woo is very self-critical and doubts if he is suitable for the work of a tutor. But despite all the self-criticism, Ki-woo is simultaneously a very dreamy, hopeful, and optimistic character. He sincerely believes that he will be able to go to the university despite all the previous failed attempts and marry Da-hye although the latter plan was understandably laughed at by the whole Kim family. With the progress of the story, we see that all those character qualities that we saw throughout the film, self-doubt and a desire for a better life were the main reason for Ki-woo to make a rash act, which eventually broke his family. But staying true to his character, even after everything he's been through, he still believes that he will be able to succeed to the point of buying the Park family's house and freeing his father.

Kim Ki-jung

The only daughter of the Kim family. Ki-jung is a very smart young woman who is just like her brother is unable to pursue a degree but, in her case, the main reason for it is actually the lack of money. She is skillful at photoshop as she was the one who forged Ki-woo's university document as well as designed fake business card which was later praised by Mr. Park. Unlike her brother she is realistic and arguably might be the only one in the Kim family who actually has a shot at climbing up the social ladder which also parallels with the fact that she is the only one who didn't have to force the replacement to get the job. Ki-jung has a dominating presence thus at her very first encounter with Choi Yeon-gyo, she was able to stand her ground and didn't let the mother to attend her lesson with Da-song which she did manage to do in Ki-woo's case during his first English lesson. Surrounded by family, Ki-jung is vulgar and uses lots of swear words but in the presence of Parks, she convincingly pretends to be a professional art therapist, although in fact she has no

qualifications for it and only follows her instincts. Ki-jung's ability to fit in is eventually the reason for her death as she was at the very center of Da-song's birthday party.

Kim Ki-taek

The father of the family who is just like his children possesses the necessary skills to infiltrate the house of the Parks. Ki-taek is an easygoing person who likes to make jokes here and there and although he is not satisfied with his current financial situation, he doesn't seem that devastated about it. It is known that throughout his life he had many jobs that unfortunately for him all failed so now he only works some odd jobs like the one where they had to fold pizza boxes. Very optimistic at first, Mr. Kim is eager to learn how to drive the unknown to him car model and during his test with Mr. Park, it is proven that he is indeed really good at it. Throughout the film, we can observe that Ki-taek receives most of all the unpleasant statements behind his back, which ultimately led to his emotional explosion and attack on Mr. Park.

Chung-sook

The mom of the Kim family. She is a very straightforward woman who used to be an athlete, we can notice that from the framed medal and a photo that are displayed on the wall. Just like her daughter, Chung-sook has realistic views on life. She is good at household chores, which allows her to easily replace the previous housekeeper and manage her duties without revealing the family's secret. At the end of the film, she was the one who can be held responsible for the old housekeeper's death although it wasn't particularly intentional.

The Kims

Kim family is very comfortable around each other. Up until the end, whatever problem they had, they dealt with it together, whether it's finding a wi-fi connection, scamming the pizzeria worker, or infiltrating the house of the Parks. Throughout the film, we can see their warm attitude towards each other, the parents aren't shy to say that they are proud of their children, even if it is for the talent of forging documents. Ki-taek has a role of a mentor for his children, especially for his son since in different parts of the film we see how he gives them advice and generally supports them in everything they do. The dynamic between Ki-woo and Ki-jung is that of typical siblings who can argue one second and help each other the other. The one relatively unusual thing is that due to the nature of their characters with Ki-woo being dreamy and generally not confident and Ki-jung being very dominant, for a viewer who watches the film with English subtitles, it is hard to understand who is the oldest. In Korean, however, the concept of honorifics makes everything much easier. Another important relationship is that of Ki-taek and Chung-sook. Looking at the age of their children, we can tell that they have been together for a long time but despite that we can see that they still very much love each other. What came with a long marriage is the bond and understanding of each other on a level that even their children cannot comprehend. This detail can be noticed during their little fake argument in the middle of the film.

Min-hyuk

The person who is indirectly responsible for the whole story. He is a friend of Ki-woo, but he is also close with Kim family in general. From the very beginning, it is clear that he comes from a family that has it better than the Kims. He is a university student who, in addition, can afford to study abroad. Based on the fact that he worked as a tutor for the Park family, we can understand that although he comes from a non-poor family, it cannot be compared to the Parks. From the conversation between Ki-woo and Min-hyuk, we

understand that they are close, but Min-hyuk may unconsciously perceive Ki-woo as a person who is not on the same level as him and therefore is not a rival, unlike his university friends. This was one of main reasons why he offered Ki-woo to replace him as a tutor.

Choi Yeon-gyo

The mother and the first member of the Park family that gets introduced to the viewer. She is described as a naïve, simple, and nice woman by multiple people throughout the film. Everything about her behavior indicates that she has a prosperous upbringing or that at least she likes to be perceived that way. Yeon-gyo is a stay-at-home mom that is not particularly talented at housework and who usually spends her time napping, shopping for groceries or waiting for her husband. It can be speculated that spending almost all the time at home is the reason why she is the one who is responsible for hiring workers for the house and paying them their salary. In fact, her trust in the hiring system through recommendations is the ultimate reason as to why the Kim family was able to easily infiltrate their house. Yeon-gyo has a particular fascination with the US which can be noticed in her trust in the US made goods and excessive use of English words.

Park Dong-ik

He is the father and the main earner of the family, who spends most of his time at work. From the very first minutes it is shown that he is incredibly successful, which can be seen not only by the chic house, but also by the certificate and the article from the magazine hanging on the wall. A very self-confident person, he clearly divides himself and people below him, whom he dislikes, but is obliged to endure, since he needs them as a workforce. In the end, his tactlessness and inability to see humanity in people below him in status is the reason why he was attacked.

The Parks

Family photos in the house make us at first perceive the Park family as ideal, but in fact they are much less friendly with each other compared to the Kim family. Several times in the film we see that the daughter dislikes her brother, since the parents' attention is largely paid only to him. From the very beginning, she says that her brother pretends to be a genius and she also does not show much desire to celebrate his birthday. Her attitude may seem groundless at first, but then it is confirmed by the scene with noodles, when the mother completely forgets about her daughter. The closeness of the relationship between Mr. Park and wife is also questioned if we consider his hesitation while answering the question whether he loves his wife or not.

Gook Moon-gwang

She is the original housekeeper of the Park family who has been in the house longer than any of the characters in the film, since she worked for the architect who built this house. Moon-gwang is good at her job and initially looks very well-groomed to the point that Ki-woo even perceives her as the owner of the house. But after her dismissal, she appears in a radically different image, and we get acquainted with her eccentric side.

Oh Geun-sae

Like Mr. Kim, he is a victim of failed businesses, but in his case, everything is much worse, and he must hide from the creditors in the house's basement. Living there for a couple of years, we can assume that his mental state has changed as well as his connection to his own humanity. Geun-sae managed to blend with the house through the light bulb through

which he conveys his gratitude towards his “saviors”. Although the very first encounter face to face between him and Mr. Park happened only at the very end of the movie, Geun-sae had a huge amount of respect towards the owner of the house. But his most meaningful relationship without a doubt were with his wife - Moon-gwang.

4.3 Analysis of signs

Parasite combines the tonal shifts of *Barking Dogs Never Bite*, the ensemble staging of *Memories of Murder*, the family dynamics of *The Host*, the ugly humanity of *Mother*, the positional symbolism of *Snowpiercer*, and the stylistic polish of *Okja*. Capitalism returns as the antagonist, but Bong voices his critique with fresher and more unique perspectives. The main point of “Parasite” is undoubtedly class disparity. Bong Joon-ho takes it upon himself to showcase it through different mediums.

The plot of the film is based on the juxtaposition of the lives of representatives of different social classes: the Kim family, living in a basement in one of the seedy districts of the city, and the Park family, owners of a luxurious house with a stylish minimalist interior and a large garden. Most of the story is told with the help of meticulously thought-out little details. To emphasize the class differences between families, the director uses the weather, elements of the urban environment, the design of apartments and much more.

4.3.1 Up and down

The film raises a popular problem of modern society – a huge gap between social classes which is expressed by external details. The very first frame begins with the camera moving from the shot of the window down on Ki-woo who trying to catch the neighbors' free Wi-Fi. Throughout the entire film, we observe the basement apartment of the Kims, where even the toilet is located above people. But not even the house and the people living in it are screaming about their low social status. South Korea is located on a hilly terrain and, of course, the Kim family lives in the lowest point of Seoul – this is clearly visible in the flood shot when the Kims are running down through brown water and garbage that is pouring down towards poor population's territories.

We see the exact opposite when Ki-woo goes to the house of Parks to teach English to their eldest daughter. The shot when he climbs up the mountain seems easy and joyful – it is here, on the Olympus of Seoul, where the houses of the rich are located. It is important that, in contrast to the Kims, the Parks are constantly depicted climbing the stairs and looking up, even lying on the couch, they do not notice the Kims hiding under the table right next to them. It is especially noteworthy that only the servants in a rich house go down to the basement, while the owners have no idea what is there.

4.3.2 Rain

Another thing to be noted is that the author chose rain, although in fact, it could have been an earthquake or a fire. Rain is something that comes from the top down, clearly showing how at the top it gives freshness and purification from dirt, but at the same time, demolishing and destroying the world that is below. If for a rich family, the rain just disrupted their trip, then for a poor one it became a symbol of disaster, doom, and the inevitability of fate. It seems to sober up the main characters from their dreams and ambitions, and spoil all the plans of the Kim family that they were building just a couple of hours before it.

4.3.3 Houses

The houses of both families were built specifically for the film, as was the entire poor neighborhood in which the basement of the Kim family is located. (O’Falt, 2019)

The House of Parks is a huge in size architectural masterpiece of modern minimalism, with designer furniture, works of art, where instead of a TV in the living room there is a giant window overlooking the outdoor garden. The Kim’s house on the other hand is located on the semi-basement, which might represent hope to its inhabitants. People don't live completely underground yet, and yet, there is a fear of falling to the very bottom, but at the same time there is a chance to get out.

In the finale, we see that the Parks have left their home, and instead there is a new family that took their place. The Kims remain to live in their basement apartment. However, Ki-woo dreams of earning money, becoming part of high society, and buying this exact house to free his hiding father. But at the end of the day, if his dream comes true, then there will be another family in the city who will live on the hill and the apartments in the basements will remain with new people living in them. On the global scale, nothing will change.

4.3.4 Chaos vs order

Another way in which Bong Joon-ho decides to showcase the poverty of the Kim family is through the accumulation of objects and textures: lack of borders, lack of free space, crowding. Utensils mixed with clothes, diplomas, and newspaper clippings, constant fuss, and color clashing determine the social status of the space. The House of Parks on the other hand is not cluttered and just looks extremely neat, all the furniture is clearly matched in color and size. Outside there is a garden with perfectly trimmed grass and bushes. Kim's basement apartment, by contrast has little space in it, and it seems that there is not even enough air. Such a reception, according to the director, is designed to emphasize the stuffiness in which the poorer part of the population must live. And this is not only the inner space of the basement of the Kims, the street and inexpensive eateries also look the same.

When the Ki-jung has already been accepted as an art therapist, and the Kims' plan works with a bang, then in the Parks' house, where there is an obvious prevailing of monotonous surfaces, she is shown in her element - among the color. And this is not the only time when chaos manifests itself in the space of the house: a fun family evening that the Kims arranged in the absence of the owners is also a great example of it.

When the Parks fire the old housekeeper and try to restore order themselves in a meantime, strict geometry is instantly under the attack. In the background of the shots, we can see kitchen utensils and lumps of dumped clothes. This is one of the dramatic flips of the film: the owners depend on the servants, without whom their ideal order instantly collapses because an order reflects a financially secure home.

4.3.5 Lightning

Already in the first shots, Bong highlights the prosperous life of the elite with the help of sunlight. The Park family is higher up in society and therefore closer to the sun. The first rays appear on the screen the moment Ki-woo starts climbing the stairs to the rich house of Parks. In an interview with IndieWire, the director and production designer Lee Ha-Jun noted that the film crew had to wait for a sunny day and a special moment for the correct setting of the frame. (O’Falt, 2019)

At the same time, we hardly see Kim's apartment on a clear day - on the contrary, it appears dark and visually loaded.

4.3.5.1 Black-and-white version

When Bong Joon-ho decided to make a black-and-white version of the film "Parasite", he somewhat decided to check whether the film is balanced enough to pass the black-and-white exam, or, in the words of the director, to become "like a classic." The black and white scale is always harmonious. Psychologist and film critic Rudolf Arnheim wrote that there can be no inconsistencies in a black-and-white frame because everything is distributed between two poles: black and white. The key communication in the film is not color or even dialogue, but light. In "Parasite", light manifests a strange, almost physiological relationship between the house and the person. Even the lamp above the stairs flashes Morse code and transmits hidden messages from people who are invisibly present in the house and therefore kind of become a part of it. These "sewn-in" messages will remain intact, whatever the version of the film may be whether colored or black and white. After all, it so happened that light is also the language of cinema. However, those who decide to watch or review the film in color will get their advantages.

On the one hand, Bong Joon-ho is not an adherent of strict color designs, the colors in his films are responsible for the atmosphere as a whole and set a kind of generalized mood: the warmth that can only be felt in your own home, or even impersonality, that allows the viewer to grasp the transparent geometry of space, like the house of Parks which is the main the place of action in "Parasite". Bong Joon-ho does not shy away from color accents — whether it is a separate detail or a peak of expressions like blood splashes on a festive table or a napkin.



Figure 2. Colored version

Source: Parasite (2019) Directed by J. Bong [Film]. South Korea: CJ Entertainment



Figure 3. Black-and-white version

Source: Parasite (2019) Directed by J. Bong [Film]. South Korea: CJ Entertainment

Colors, or rather, palettes, determine the character of the place. All of them are instrumental in relation to action: theme defines the color. The office rooms at Bong Joon-ho's films are colorless, the torture rooms are gloomy and monotonous. If he shoots a scene about natural harmony (as, for example, in the opening scenes of the previous film "Okja"), then there will be a lot of greenery, shimmering lakes, and air permeated with sunlight. If we are talking about a sexual maniac (as in "Memories of Murder") — the forest becomes dark — brown-green.

In Parasite the director likes to show the status of the Parks using minimalism and order. And due to the minimalism even in color, it's almost a black-and-white movie whenever we see the rich family in their own habitat.

4.3.6 Windows

Both houses possess windows that make viewers understand the differences between families' financial statuses. One is almost at a street level and overlooks dirty sidewalks and garbage cans, the other, however, extends to the entire wall, completely replacing it. Kim's family is forced to watch drunk people urinate right in front of their window, while Parks can enjoy the pretty view from the comfort of their couch. The windows provide the natural source of light and the difference in sizes essentially represents that the poorer you are, the less sunlight you get.



Figure 4. Kim family's window

Source: Parasite (2019) Directed by J. Bong [Film]. South Korea: CJ Entertainment



Figure 5. The window in Park family's house

Source: Parasite (2019) Directed by J. Bong [Film]. South Korea: CJ Entertainment

4.3.7 Stairs

In addition, the houses seem to exist on different levels of the city. To get into the apartment of a poor family, you need to go down the stairs. And when approaching the house of Parks, you first have to climb the mountain and then several flights of stairs. Such a reception, according to the director, is intended to once again emphasize the insurmountable difference between families. The internal structure of houses also reminds of this. Climbing the stairs in the house of Parks, the heroes get into the bedroom, and the only steps in the Kims' apartment led to the toilet.

When we find out about the existence of a basement in the house, where a former housekeeper hides her husband from collectors, it becomes clear that it is a hopeless bottom which is almost impossible to rise from. Important to note that for all the time of

owning their house, the rich did not even know about the existence of a bunker. This could mean that Parks are not even interested in what is happening below them.

The viewer sees the full picture of the social gap only at the climax: when the plans of the Kim family collapse and they run home in the pouring rain. Before reaching their home, the family must run along infinitely long stairs and eventually find themselves at the very bottom. "I really wanted that sequence to feel like it was connecting the rich neighborhood to the poorer neighborhood in real time. That's one singular duration. Rain flows throughout that entire sequence." said Bong Joon-ho. (O'Falt, 2019)

4.3.8 Line

The head of the Park family has noticed more than once that he can't stand it when people cross the line. With an original visual technique, Bong Joon-ho showed how these very lines divide the rich and the poor: in many frames of the film, you can see that Parks are separated from the Kims by certain vertical lines. As if no matter how much the Kims dream, they will never cross it.

4.3.9 Smell

This symbol is introduced when the entire Kim family has already infiltrated the house of Parks, masquerading as strangers at various jobs. As Bong Joon-ho says: *"The jobs that these characters take ... feature a rare moment where the rich and poor are together in a very private space and so close to one another that they can smell each other."* (Paiella, 2019)

When the Da-song discovers that all the workers smell the same, he unknowingly threatens to reveal their real identities. The "smell" represents poverty, which the Kims, and in particular the father, Kim Ki-taek, cannot get rid of. The motif of the "smell" comes back again and again, reminding Ki-taek of his place in the lower class.

The last time the "smell" appears at the climax of the film, when Mr. Park has to take the car keys that happened to get thrown next to Geun-sae, who spend years in a basement. Mr. Park closes his nose in disgust, this gesture is a vivid representation what the character feels for everyone below him in status and was the last straw for Ki-taek, who had reached the boiling point.

4.3.10 Appearance

Another distinguishing factor of the heroes is appearance. Of course, in any country in the world, people judge a person's wealth "by their clothes", but for South Korea, it is especially true. Many, at first glance, unremarkable details in the appearance of the characters play a huge role in "Parasite". Ki-woo has an unstylish haircut which is especially noticeable next to Min-hyuk and Ki-jung has single eyelids, which is unfavorable compared to double eyelids. Similarly the parents have a tan skin tone, which is another undesirable trait among country's population. The whole family wears colorless clothes, which for the viewer who knows about South Korean beauty standards screams about their low social status. (Wang, 2022)

At the same time, all members of the Park family have perfect faces, styling and expensive well-fitted clothes. The actors are perfectly matched with today's standards of beauty which prevail in the south part of the peninsula. Likewise, it can be noticed that the Park

children look alike but are different from their parents. If mom and dad are thin and tall with long noses and oval faces, then children have cute cheeks and round eyes– the very "ideal" for their generation.

4.3.11 The United States

A large number of countries are heavily influenced by the United States, but this is especially true for South Korea because of their long-term military alliance and Bong Joon-ho did not forget to add this detail to "Parasite". The USA has been an example of the right life and quality for rich South Koreans, that's why Mrs. Park constantly uses English words, talks about American goods, American universities and acquaintances living in the USA. (Nguyen and Tran-Nguyen, 2022)

Throughout the film, we see Da-song's obsession with Native Americans – the boy runs around in the stereotypical fake cultural clothes. This point wasn't added by chance as it additionally showcases the ignorance of the Park family. For them the headdress, the war chants and the teepee are just surface level decorations, meaning they don't see the rich culture and therefore the people behind it. (Chu, 2019)

When watching the movie, it may seem strange that none of the invited guests noticed the appearance of Geun-sae with a bloody face and a knife in his hand. But by understanding that the whole celebration is based on the stereotypical portrayal of Native American culture and that people who were invited to that party are similar to the Parks and therefore probably as ignorant, we can come to the conclusion that for them Geun-sae's appearance might have looked fitting with the whole visual part of the party.

4.3.12 Scholar stone

Another interesting point relates to the landscape rock that the Kim family receives as a gift from Min-hyuk's grandparent at the very beginning. The director himself says that he wanted to draw the attention of the audience to this stone and create a little intrigue. Min-hyuk says that the stone is supposed to bring material well-being. The audience thinks that maybe this is some kind of metaphor and at some point, Ki-woo himself says that this is a metaphor, and thus making everything even more intriguing. It was the stone that was the only thing that Ki-woo took from his flooded house: it became something like a talisman for him. When he decides to deal with the inhabitants of the basement on his own, his choice of weapon is the stone. But ironically, the stone became the beginning of the end of the Kim family. The director himself said that at the beginning of the story, the stone reflects the desire of Ki-woo to raise the social and material status of his family. He imitates his friend, who is much more successful than him. Later Min-hyuk no longer appears in the film but the stone becomes some sort of a remnant of the character. And if at first, the stone symbolizes the desire for wealth and status, after the flood, whenever we see Ki-woo desperately clinging to the stone, it rather represents his attempts to cling to his elusive dreams, goals and plans. (Vanity Fair, 2019)

4.4 Inherently South Korean aspects of Parasite

There are other means that suggest the director's main point. However, they might not be that evident, at least to a western or more specifically non-Korean eye. What makes them different from previously mentioned examples is that they require a more profound knowledge of the intricacies of Korean culture that people from the western world just can't obtain unless they make an additional effort.

The Korean aspect of this film is worked out to the smallest detail. The architecture, landscape, and atmosphere of almost every place are unmistakably Korean. The brands that were used, the placement of extraneous objects like advertisements, baskets, etc. show Korean cultural elements to the smallest detail.

The lines between each character seem to be drawn, and the viewer becomes a participant in the creation of the picture, in other words, he seems to be present at the moment of creation, and, I would say, through cultural symbolism, not only visual perception appears, but olfactory, like the 5-D effect.

An important detail worth paying attention to is how elements of national culture are used not for the general entourage, but as elements that move the plot forward. Elements of Korean culture were not boastful and did not overflow the frame but looked organically. The elaboration of the slightest elements, for example, how a Korean diploma looks in the scene where it is forged, distinguishes this film in the field of international cinema.

4.4.1 Food

Food is one of the moments to which the director devotes a lot of time in the film and which is intended to emphasize the difference between two families and, accordingly, social classes. First, it is, of course, instant noodles 짜파구리 ("Chaphaguri"). Like any other types of instant noodles, it costs very cheap. The name itself sounds funny to the Korean ear, because three names of the original types of cheap food are mixed here at once. Firstly, it is "jjajangmyeon" — simple noodles in black sauce, traditionally considered a quick and cheap snack. One of the companies that puts instant noodles on the market decided to "enhance" the image of its product a little, took the first syllable from the "jjajangmyeon" noodles and added part of the word "spaghetti" — a dish that is considered Western in Korea, and therefore elite. It turned out to be "Chapagetti", which is ridiculous in itself. Then Bong Junho himself invented the word 짜파구리 ("Chaphaguri") by mixing up «Chapagetti», with another cheap, but very spicy noodles — "Noguri" ("Raccoon"). Not only does it sound funny in Korean, it's also an extremely cheap low-quality product in the style of "leaving everything that was in the refrigerator and cooked in one pot." In addition, there was also a play on words: in the Korean language there is an ending "구려" (-gure), which sounds very close to this very "-guri" and means "cheap, fake, junk goods with zero quality". Therefore, for any Korean viewer, the scene when a housekeeper in a rich house cooks chaphaguri noodles for Da-song as snack, it is already a sitcom. Cheap "ramen" with Hanwoo, a very expensive Korean marble beef. This contrast is understandable to every Korean as well as sarcasm on the part of the director, showing the difference in the standard of living of the poor and the rich.

The scenes with alcohol are also indicative of those differences. There are three important appearances of the alcohol in the film: the first time at the beginning of the film, when a poor family has dinner in their basement apartment, the second time in the same apartment, but after everyone got a job in a rich family, and the third time — already in a rich house, when owners have gone on a trip. This detail is very important. For the first time, everyone drinks beer "FiLite" (read as "Fillight", 필라이트). This is the cheapest beer that can be found in Korea. "FiLite" is one of the alternatives of the beer "Hite", which was specially released in a cheap version. It is worse in quality, since it is made from the remnants of what went into making normal beer. For the second time (after getting a job in a rich house), the heroes have not only the "FiLite" on the table, but also "Sapporo premium" — imported and (relatively) expensive and high-quality beer from Japan. It is

already becoming clear that money has begun to appear. And in the end, in a rich house they drink whiskey.

The same thing could be said about the food that Kim family consumes throughout the film. They are shown to eat at a Drivers' Cafeteria (기사식당), which is a very cheap place to it at. Then they are shown to eat at a pizza place that they used to work for and to add, they were even served by their former boss. Later Kim family is seen eating home-made rice, kimchi and eggs. And near the middle of the film, they eat proper meat.

4.4.2 Jessica's song

For non-Korean people, this tune might seem like just a good find of the director and an interesting way of interaction between the main characters. In fact, the meaning here is deeper. Initially, this song is about the Dokdo Islands, a disputed territory between South Korea and Japan, in which it is sung that "Dokdo is our land". This song is very known and is sung in elementary school lessons. Therefore, the director turned an innocent children's melody into one of the key symbols of lies in the whole film. This is another way in which he shows how deeply lies are ingrained in the minds of a poor family and how cleverly and skillfully these people adapt to any situation, not disdaining any moral principles.

4.4.3 Names

Symbolism is also present in the names of the main characters. The father of the poor family is called Ki-taek, his son is Ki-woo, and his daughter is Ki-jung. On the official page of the film, the names are written using Chinese characters, which in itself is not surprising: 99% of all Korean names have hieroglyphic roots. It is another thing that is surprising: usually the hieroglyph "ki" used in people's names is either a symbol meaning "get up", or another hieroglyph meaning "strength, power". However, in the names of the father and son, the director put a hieroglyph that is not used in the names of people, that means: "join, stick, adjust." The same hieroglyph (寄) is the first in the word "kisenchun" (기생충, 寄生, "Parasite" the title of the film). This word is made up of three Chinese characters: "stick", "life" and "insect" — "a living organism that sticks to others, which lives at the expense of others." Thus, the character of the family, their life values are already visible in their names, which, of course, is immediately visible to attentive Korean speaking people. The mother of a poor family also has a very unusual name — Moon-gwang, in which two hieroglyphs literally mean "gates, doors" and "madness".

4.4.4 Subtitles

Several times in the film, it can be noticed how English subtitles are adapted for a western viewer. In the very first scene, the characters say Kakaotalk instead of WhatsApp that is used in subtitles. Kakaotalk is the most used messenger in South Korea which is unknown to those outside of the country.

To follow-up on ramen, the other difference was in the name of the made-up dish. If in Korean, it was called "jjapaguri" then in English the translator decided to rely on the combination of shots of the packaged noodles with the words ramen and udon thus the word that the viewers was on the screen was "ramdon". (KOREA NOW, 2019)

South Korean universities are unknown to people who had no connection to South Korea prior to "Parasite". So, for a foreign viewer to fully understand the prestige of the university that Ki-jung and Ki-woo decided to forge the certificate of, the translator

changed the actual name Yonsei University to Oxford University which is much more familiar.

4.4.5 Honorifics

Honorifics are a huge part of the Korean language and culture. And due to the lack of them in English it is hard to convey the level of respect with which characters address each other. In Korean, there are special appeals to people depending on the hierarchical social status and gender of the interlocutor.

The most important scene in this aspect is the scene when the Kim family discovers that the old housekeeper has been hiding her husband inside Parks' family house for four years. When Moon-gwang pleads Mrs. Kim to keep her secret the subtitles say that she calls her "sis" but in Korean she uses the word 언니 (eonni) which is used by the younger sister when addressing an older one, it can also be used in informal communication when a younger member of the team addresses an older one. Thus, by using this word, an old housekeeper was basically trying to appear closer to Mrs. Kim as well as show her respect. But as Chung-sook doesn't want to be associated with Moon-gwang, she quickly tells her not to call her that. However, the power dynamic shifts when the old housekeeper finds out about the Kim family's secret. And if before Moon-gwang used formal speech while talking to Mrs. Kim, after the reveal, she started to use swear words and refused to be called 동생 (dongsang) which means younger sibling. In subtitles, however, the word dongsang was once again translated as "sis". (KoreanClass101, 2019)

4.5 Who is Parasite?

As in all recent works, Bong Joon-ho is not shy when it comes to metaphors and is not afraid of unambiguous interpretations. Moreover, he openly mocks himself, using the voice of Ki-woo when he suddenly says, "*this is metaphoric*." The director is not interested in hidden meanings and complex allegories — everything lies on the surface, and what is much more interesting is not what his movie is about because to understand this, it is enough to read the synopsis, but how far Bong Joon-ho will lead his film with style and signs. If at the beginning it is obvious to us who is hiding under the term "parasite", but then by the end the film, the title takes on global and comprehensive meaning: parasites can be poor, parasites can be rich, parasites are in the kitchen and the basement, inside and outside, on both sides of the screen. It's all a metaphor, yes, but no one warned how broad it is. In the end, we conclude that the main parasite is the system itself. And the longer this system will exist, the longer this pattern will continue. The rich will stay rich, and the poor will stay poor.

Conclusion

Bong Joon-jo could be considered among the most intriguing filmmakers. He managed to find the approval not only from his audience, but also other people in the industry. Even though in the west his filmmaking talent was rightfully awarded only relatively recently, back home he has been an inspiration for young talents for more than a decade. Nowadays, when the film market is as full as it gets, Bong's exceptional talent in the art of film is especially appreciated. The question is, what makes him different?

The whole South Korean film industry is famous for its ability to juggle different genres, but Bong Joon-ho honed this skill from film to film and in "Parasite", he has reached its apogee thus far. Social satire is layered on a family drama, seasoned with black comedy, and then turns into a chamber thriller and bloody horror. It turns out that for two hours the viewer doesn't really know what to expect next.

Bong Joon-ho demonstrated the ability to combine personal drama, satire, black comedy, and social messages since his debut work, "Barking Dogs Never Bite." Even while watching the subsequent "Memories of Murder", suspense does not prevent a bitter smile from surfacing in response to absurd actions and police interrogations. "The Host" is shot in the genre of fiction, which is seasoned with comedy and family drama, but does not lose sight of environmental and socio-political themes. Okja is the director's first film to receive a nomination for the Palme d'Or. It is a touching story about friendship, as well as a reflection on the topic of ecology and total deception of corporations.

In every Bong's film we can follow one detail and it is the fact that every story is about ordinary flawed people. Instead of the right and the guilty, there is a microscopic analysis of characters, where each member of society assumes the function of a parasite: both the poor, who enjoy the benefits of the rich, and the well-fed rich, who are not able to live a day without service personnel - the tape draws a mutual parasitic existence that underlies capitalist logic.

The director does his best to refrain from his moral position, leaving the spectacle to the audience's judgment – this gesture of self-exclusion in many ways made the "Parasite" a cultural and cinematic phenomenon.

Although the film brings us to the fact that Kim Ki-woo has a plan to get rich and buy out the house in the basement of which his father is now hiding, the director erases this illusion with a subsequent shot when the camera descends into the same basement apartment from which the film began.

The thesis further analyzed the specific tools that Bong uses to captivate the viewer and which we could observe in his works. First, it is the specific narrative structure. This way of narrative is one of the ways of storytelling, or cinematic storytelling, in which Bong draws the audience into the story. This unconventional way of processing allows the director to differ even more from the conventions of classical American cinema. The films are always based on characters and their internal conflicts as well as the unique chemistry between each of the main characters.

Another element of uniqueness is the attention to detail that Bong masterfully conveys to the viewer. He can very well harmonize the setting and lighting of the scene and details so that they become the central and memorable for the story. Bong's controversial humor is

also exceptionally fitting, and the director manages to combine it well in contrast to the dramatic scenes.

Another aspect that helps Bong to create an interesting film for an audience is the use of specific cultural elements. For South Korean person they will arouse the sense of relatability or nostalgia and for a person who is not familiar with the culture, it might introduce him to something new. But what is important to mention is that these cultural details although might enrich the overall message of the film, at the same time they do not stand at the forefront, meaning that not knowing them, will not make the viewer lose the point of the plot.

Bong's films very often stimulate social debates because they carry strong themes and come from the environment of ordinary society. There is almost always a deeper essence, designed to highlight thorny topics, or reflect the situation in society. Bong is always able to find new possibilities in these themes, just like this, the concept of class inequality can be followed throughout his whole filmography. His art is very strongly built on visuals and thanks to that Bong Joon-ho continues to push the boundaries of cinema all over the world.

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